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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Section Title(S)

Internal Organization of the Neighbourhood

Public opinion therefore has an institutionalized outlet rather through the Drum and the young people's dance than in the clan joking-relationship. Clan joking-partners are still of importance. They have the task of ensuring that funeral rites are properly carried out, and they do much of the work during funerals. They can be asked to serve as go-betweens in matters of negotiation. They also give a person some assurance of support beyond his neighbourhood since the alliance is a constant one with the same clans paired together in all the territory stretching from the Zambezi to the Plateau. Within the neighbourhood, the institution also gives a measure of stability, for it operates to apportion some of the work of the local rituals. Clans in a joking-relationship with the clan of the *sikatongo* have their set duties in the building or repair of a shrine and in the various rites performed at the shrine.

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In Upper River region, the Drum and the young people's dance also publicize scandal. The clan joking-relationship is not present, with the one possible exception mentioned above, and people use the word *bujwanyina* only with reference to the intertribal joking-relationships which they find in the urban areas. Then Tonga men are treated as joking-partners by Lozi, and the two help one another.¹

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The *basilufulo* take over responsibility for funerals and for certain other matters. One can summon as a *silufulo* anyone of the same clan who does not belong to one's lineage, but each old-established lineage usually has one other lineage which it considers its primary *silufulo* partner. The relationship is reciprocal. At SIAMEJA, the lineages of Siameja and Sianenge are partners. On the death of any member of Siameja, word immediately is sent to Sianenge. If the dead person has been an important member of the lineage, one of the two male shade holders of Sianenge will serve as *silufulo*. Otherwise some other man will be appointed to carry out the duties. Whoever agrees to serve must continue to do so throughout the funeral. He cannot turn his duties over to another. With the male *silufulo* will be associated a woman *silufulo*, who also has her role to play. The father's lineage of the dead also summons a *silufulo* partner to take charge of its responsibilities during the funeral. It too appoints a man and a woman to perform its functions. The male *basilufulo* serve as go-betweens in any negotiations; they take charge of the digging of the grave and the burial; they butcher animals slaughtered for the occasion and in consultation with the two bereaved lineages decide upon the distribution of the meat; they arrange for the bringing of firewood; they are involved in the consultation with the diviner to find the cause of death; and they are in charge of the inquest at which the divination is announced. The women *basilufulo* are in charge of the contributions of grain and arrange for its preparation, help to apportion the food, and have the responsibility of caring for the widows if the deceased was a man. Both male and female *basilufulo* supervise the ritual shaving, today performed only by women, and the anointing of the mourners with red ochre. The male or female *silufulo* of the lineage of the dead must be present when the shade is inherited, and later, when the inheritor first makes an offering to the shade, it is the *silufulo* of his or her sex who begins the offering and hands the gourd ladle to the inheritor. When a male inheritor seeks a new ritual wife, it is a *silufulo* who must negotiate the marriage and bring the wife to his homestead. In the past when a child which cut its upper teeth first was to be disposed of, it was a *silufulo* who took it to the Zambezi and threw it into a deep pool.

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¹ When I wrote of the Plateau Tonga clan joking-relationship, I had not heard of the intertribal joking-relationship. Today all the younger men in the Valley know about it, but older men, in the age group over fifty, say that it did not exist when they were going out to work. The Lozi-Tonga joking-relationship may therefore be a new thing, but further work needs to be done on this subject.

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